co-existence" and "Panchsheel" that our leaders are indulging in only serve as a camouflage for the self-seeking predatory countries of the world to pursue their own ulterior motives against our country. China, as we know, was most vociferous in its expression of faith in Panchsheel. China was extolled as our great neighbour and friend for the last two thousand years or more from the day it accepted Buddhism. Our leaders declared that they were determined to stick to China's friendship "at all costs" … How much it has cost us in terms of our national integrity and honour is all too well known.'

Writing in 1998, the journalist M.V. Kamath named names. Saluting the nuclear tests overseen by the BJP, he recalled the 'time, under Jawaharlal Nehru and V.K. Krishna Menon when a decision must have been taken not to engage in a "debilitating and criminally wasteful arms race"; it was very noble of the two gentlemen who taught us to sing Hindi–Chini-bhai–bhai in chorus. For our efforts China kicked us in the teeth.'

Kamath was writing decades after the conflict, but a contemporary expression of this point of view can be found in the writings of Deen Dayal Upadhyaya, the leading ideologue of the BJP's mother party, the Jana Sangh. When the first clashes broke out on the border in September 1959, Upadhyaya argued that 'the present situation is the result of complacency on the part of the Prime Minister. It seems that he was reluctant to take any action till the situation became really grave.' The Jana Sangh leader complained that Nehru had 'more faith in his Panch Sheel perorations than in preparation and performance'. The prime minister was compared to the notoriously incompetent nineteenth-century ruler of Awadh, Wajid Ali Shah. 'Only he [Nehru] knows when a crisis is not a crisis,' wrote Upadhyaya sarcastically; only Nehru knew 'how to emit smoke without fire and how to arrest a conflagration in a Niagara of verbiage!'

Week after week, Upadhyaya excoriated Nehru's China policy in the pages of the RSS journal, *Organiser*. 'As usual the Prime Minister has exhibited his temperamental weakness in dealing with the issue of Chinese aggression,' he remarked. 'Why can't he [the Prime Minister]—with equal